Commercial Break

By Augusten Burroughs

AB: **(Pgs 1-16)** When I was seven, I was plucked out of an uneventful life deep in darkest Massachusetts and dropped into a Tang Instant Breakfast Drink commercial. It was exactly like being abducted by aliens. I was a lonely kid with entirely imaginary friends. I played with trees. Then, one day during penmanship class, a white van pulled up in front of our little gray schoolhouse, and the men from Tang climbed out.

INTRODUCTION

TV VOICE:
Enjoyed by consumers in more than 60 countries, Tang is one of Kraft's most global brands and one of our largest. Kraft holds the number one position in powdered beverages in the world and our Tang brand is an important part of that portfolio. The combination of the great fruit taste of Tang, its nutritional benefits, convenience and affordable price has made it a favorite among millions. Since the early '80s, Tang has been launched in approximately 30 countries. And now back to your regular programming. . . Thanks for your attention during this

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AB: I was sitting in Mrs. Ames's tedious penmanship class looking out the window when the white van pulled into the circular driveway. Mrs. Ames noticed, too, because she paused in the middle of looping a "D". Visitors were uncommon at our school. Especially visitors dressed in dark suits, wearing sunglasses, and carrying black briefcases. When [Mrs. Ames] turned her ancient neck to the window, my mind added the sound effect of a branch creaking under the weight of snow before it snaps. I was quite sure that Mrs. Ames was one of the original settlers of the town. She once said that television was *(imitating Ames)* "nonsense, just a fad like radio."

MRS. AMES: *(glaring at the class)* Remain seated and do not talk. I shall return in a moment.

AB: A moment later, Mrs, Ames joined the men outside and, to my horror, smiled. I'd never seen Mrs. Ames smile before, and the thought had never occurred to me that such an act was even possible. But there it was, her mouth open in the white daylight, her teeth exposed. *(smile as Mrs. Ames)* One of the men stepped forward, removed his sunglasses,

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and said something to her. She touched her hair with her hand and laughed. I was horrified to see Mrs. Ames laugh. And then blush. To see her in such a state of obvious bliss was unbearable. I had to look away.

Eventually, Mrs. Ames walked back into the room, and I watched her legs, all plump and plastic-looking through her support hose. She wore high heels of an unfashionable style that made a sharp, angry sklack against the tile floor when she walked.

MRS. AMES: Children, children, may I have your attention please? *(clapping her hands)* "We have some very special surprise guests here today. These men are here to make a television commercial.

AB: Well, I almost peed. She might as well have told me that I never had to come to school again and I was free to hit anybody I wanted to, without being punished. I loved television commercials. The only reason I watched TV was so that I could see the commercials. Faberge Organics Shampoo: *(imitating the commercial)* "I told two friends. And they told two friends. And so on. . . and so on. . . and so on." Or my current favorite: *(imitating the commercial)* "Gee, your hair smells terrific!" I was also fond of the commercial with little dog chasing the chuck wagon underneath the kitchen sink.

MRS. AMES: *(to the class)* These men would like to put our schoolhouse in a commercial for Tang. Do any of you know Tang?"

AB: There were gasps in the room. Of course, we knew Tang, the orange crystalline powder that the astronauts brought with them to outer space. I loved Tang and would sometimes eat it by the teaspoon, straight from the jar. I loved the green label, the orange lid. The way the lid was extra wide and easy to unscrew. I even liked the paper eardrum that was over the mouth of the lid when you first opened the jar. You had to puncture the eardrum with a spoon, and printed on top was "Tang, Tang, Tang."

Mrs. Ames told us that the men wanted to use some of us in their commercial. Instantly, the students began raising their hands. Except for me. Some voice inside me said, "Don't do it. It's beneath you." Instead, I sat politely at my desk with my hands clasped firmly together. One thing was certain: I ***would*** be in their Tang commercial.

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The interviews began in groups of three. When it was finally my turn, the men were tired, as evidenced by their loosened ties and the large wet spots that spread under their arms. They'd spoken to thirty kids and had notes piled on the table in front of them.

MAN 1: Hi guys. So do any of you want to be in a commercial? *(AB nods vigorously)* Good. So, I'm gonna tell a joke, and I want to see what it sounds like when you laugh. Ready? Okay. *(raises voice and makes a comical face)* Your mother wears army boots!

AB: *(looks left, then right)* Neither of the other kids laughed. *(laughs hysterically, then proudly)* I was able to bring tears to my eyes. My face was flushed, my hands dripping with sweat.

MAN 1: Wow, you really liked that joke, did you? Do you kids like Tang?

AB: The other two kids nodded grimly. *(to man, gushing)* I love Tang! Only I like to make it with an extra scoop. Plus, you can put it in ice cube trays and then freeze it! *(to audience)* Where had that come from? I'd never in my life frozen Tang.

MAN 1: That's great! What's your name?

AB: Augusten?

MAN 1: Augusten. You were great. We want you.

AB: As soon as I got home, I sprinted up our gravel driveway and threw open the front door, screaming "I'm gonna be in a Tang commercial! I'm gonna be in a Tang commercial!" In preparation for my television acting debut, I watched commercials incessantly, committing them to memory and reciting phrases endlessly. *(as if on camera. . .)*

(in a high-pitched girl's voice) Can I help you fry the chicken?

(different southern girl's voice) I want to help!

(imitating their mother) I don't fry chicken anymore. I use new Shake 'N Bake.

(mimicking another commercial) Let's get Mikey to try it. He won't eat it; he hates everything!

I loved to sing jingles. *(singing)* * "That great Pepsi taste. Diet Pepsi won't go to your waist. Now you see it. Now you don't. Oh, Diet Pepsi one small calorie. Now you see it. Now you don't."

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DAD: Son, what's the matter with you? If you don't stop that noise, you won't be in any commercial. You'll be back in your room practicing penmanship.

AB: Oh, Diet Pepsi one small calorie. Now you see it. Now you don't . . . *(trailing off)* This muted me, briefly. Long enough to contemplate his sudden death and wonder how I would ever be able to produce convincing tears. Onions, I'd heard, could do the trick if you applied just a small bit of the juice under your eye. I tried this myself, thrilled with the weepy, sincere results: *(dramatically)* Oh Dad! Boo-hoo-hoo.

*******The next day at filming******

DIRECTOR: *(angrily)* CUT! Why is this so hard for you? All you have to do is say 'Hey, Mark, where are you going?' That's all you have to say. Why are you having so much trouble with this?

AB: I don't know. Something is throwing me out of character.

DIRECTOR: What are you talking about You're a kid in a school. . . playing a kid in a school!

AB: We'd been shooting for over an hour. It was a simple setup: I was walking behind a group of other kids when I suddenly see my friend, Mark. I pause, turn toward the camera without looking at it and say, "Hey, Mark, where are you going?" But I just couldn't do it. Each time I spoke my line, my voice sounded forced, pretentious, dishonest. These were concepts I'd gleaned from a copy of Acting: A Handbook of the Stanislavski Method, which I'd found on my mother's bookshelf.

The other problem was that I didn't feel I had ***found*** my character. Why was I walking down the hall? Was I going to class? Or coming from class? These were essential questions, and the director refused to provide answers.

DIRECTOR: Will you shut up and just walk! ACTION!

AB: And I began my walk down the hallway, fully aware of the camera trained on my every move. I concentrated hard on being normal. But I could feel it happening. Like being the passenger in a car speeding out of control, I was unable to stop myself. *(in a high-pitched and overly rehearsed tone of voice)* "Hey, Mark, where are you going?"

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I waited for the director to again scream "Cut!" but instead there was silence. And then I felt a rush. Had I done it? Had I accidentally done it exactly right? *(biting his lip to repress the smile)*

DIRECTOR: Forget it. We'll fix it in the edit. This is a wrap!

*******Scene change*******

AB: Finally the day arrived. My mother turned on the Today Show, and we watched for nearly an hour before it came on. I saw myself for a split second, in back of a bunch of kids. One girl said, "Hey, let's go get some!" and the scene cut to Mrs. Ames at home serving Tang to her grandchildren for the rest of the commercial. My line had been cut! Mrs. Ames hijacked the commercial!

Depressed, I walked down the hall to my room. *(in a natural voice)* "Hey, Mark, where are you going?" I realized at once that this is what the director had wanted all along. He didn't want passion, meaning, and nuance. He wanted an ordinary kid who would say six words.
I decided, right there. I won't be a child actor for television commercials. Instead, I will be the one who thinks up the commercials in the first place. And then I will hire the director myself, and when he can't make the kid give me a passionate, meaningful, and nuanced performance, I'll fire him.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Augusten Burroughs
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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

**** Lyrics and Music for the Diet Pepsi commercial can be found here:***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=__pOOOpJ58U

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